

A DATA STORY IN 13 QUESTIONS

Can You Actually Make Money With a Startup?

We looked inside 1,000 real online businesses — their real, bank-verified income — to see what actually happens after someone launches a startup. This is what the numbers say.

In plain terms: “TrustMRR” is a website where small startup founders connect their real payment account (like Stripe) to publicly prove exactly how much money their business makes — no exaggeration allowed. We studied 1,000 of these public, verified profiles.

What Exactly Is In This Dataset?

1

1 Row = 1 Real Startup

Each of the 1,000 records is one company — its income, growth, category, and audience, all in one place.

2

Verified, Not Self-Reported

Numbers come straight from payment providers (Stripe, RevenueCat, Polar...) so founders can't inflate them.

3

Some Are Also for Sale

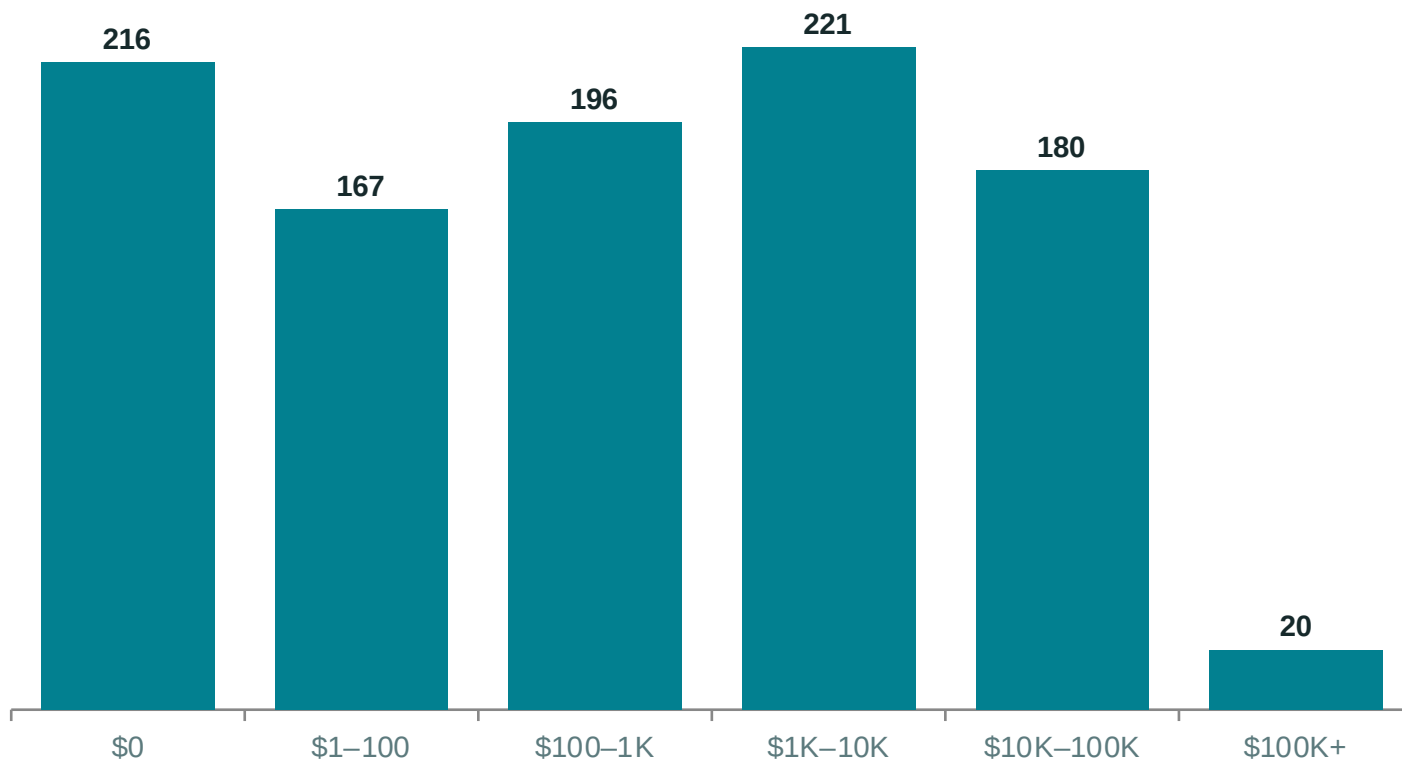
A portion of these startups list an asking price — this dataset doubles as a mini acquisition marketplace.

THE ANSWER TrustMRR is like a public “proof of income” directory for indie founders — this deck turns 1,000 of those verified profiles into one big-picture story.

QUESTION 2

How Much Do These Startups Actually Make?

Number of startups by last-30-day revenue



21.6%

of startups made \$0 in the last 30 days

Only 2%

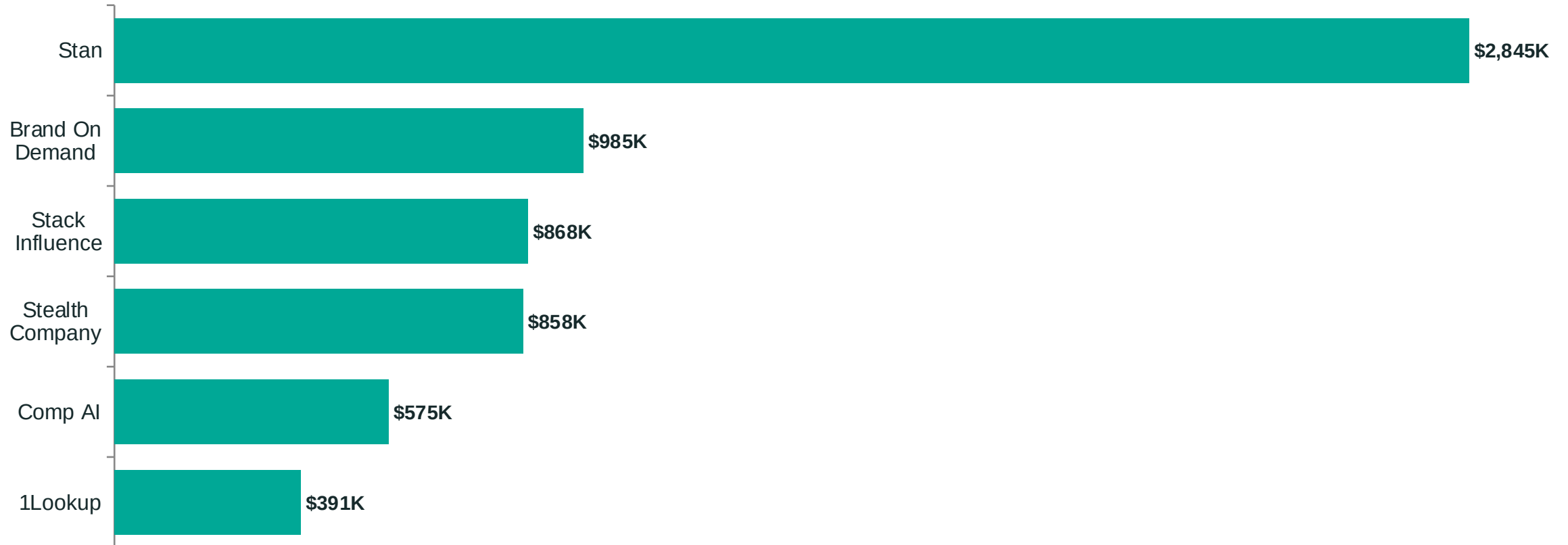
crossed \$100,000 in monthly revenue

THE ANSWER Not much, typically. The median startup earns just \$399.50/month — most never turn into a real income.

QUESTION 3

Who Are the Handful of Big Winners?

Top 6 startups by last-30-day revenue (USD)

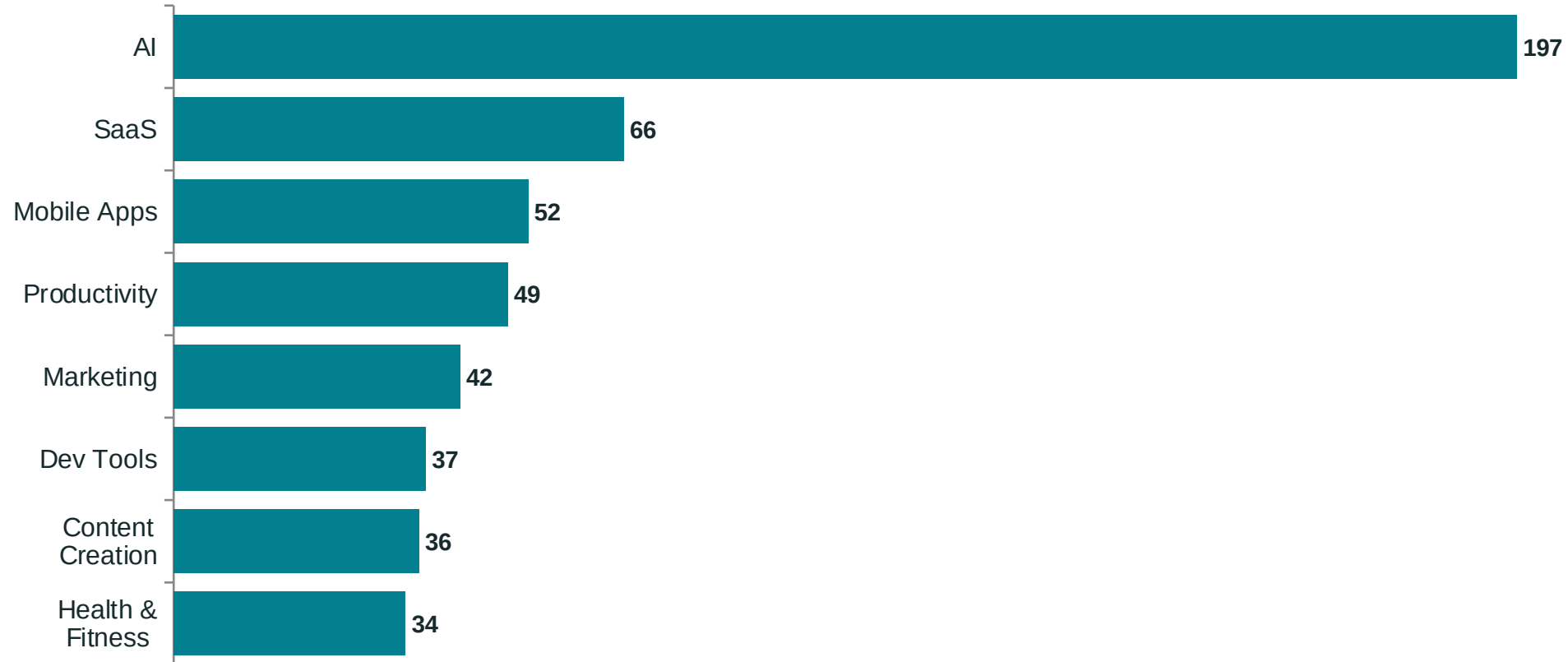


THE ANSWER A tiny few. “Stan” alone made \$2.84M in one month — more than the bottom 700 startups combined. Success is a long tail, not a bell curve.

QUESTION 4

What Is Everyone Actually Building?

Number of startups per top category

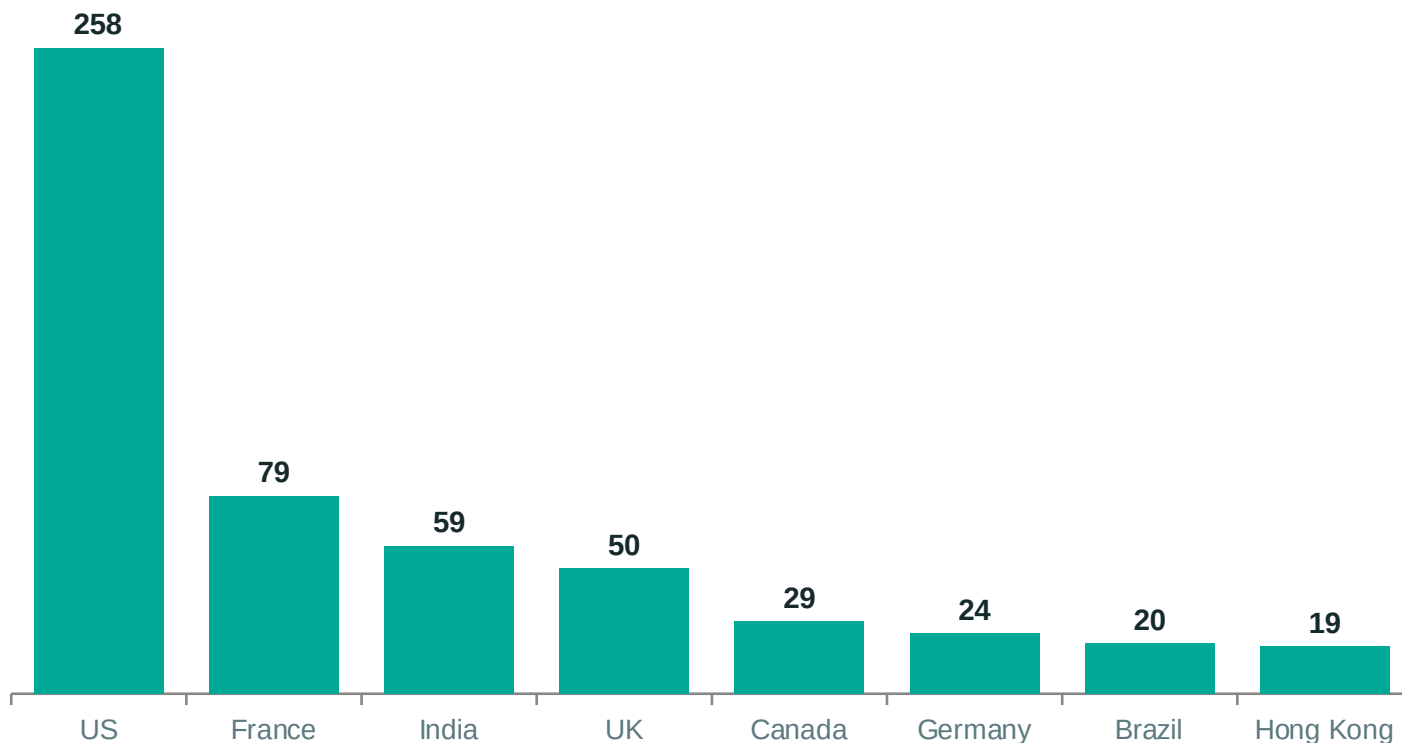


THE ANSWER AI, by a mile. Nearly 1 in 5 startups (197 of 1,000) is an AI product — 3x more common than the next category, SaaS.

QUESTION 5

Where in the World Are They Building?

Top 8 countries by number of startups



25.8%

of all startups are US-based — 1 in every 4

24%

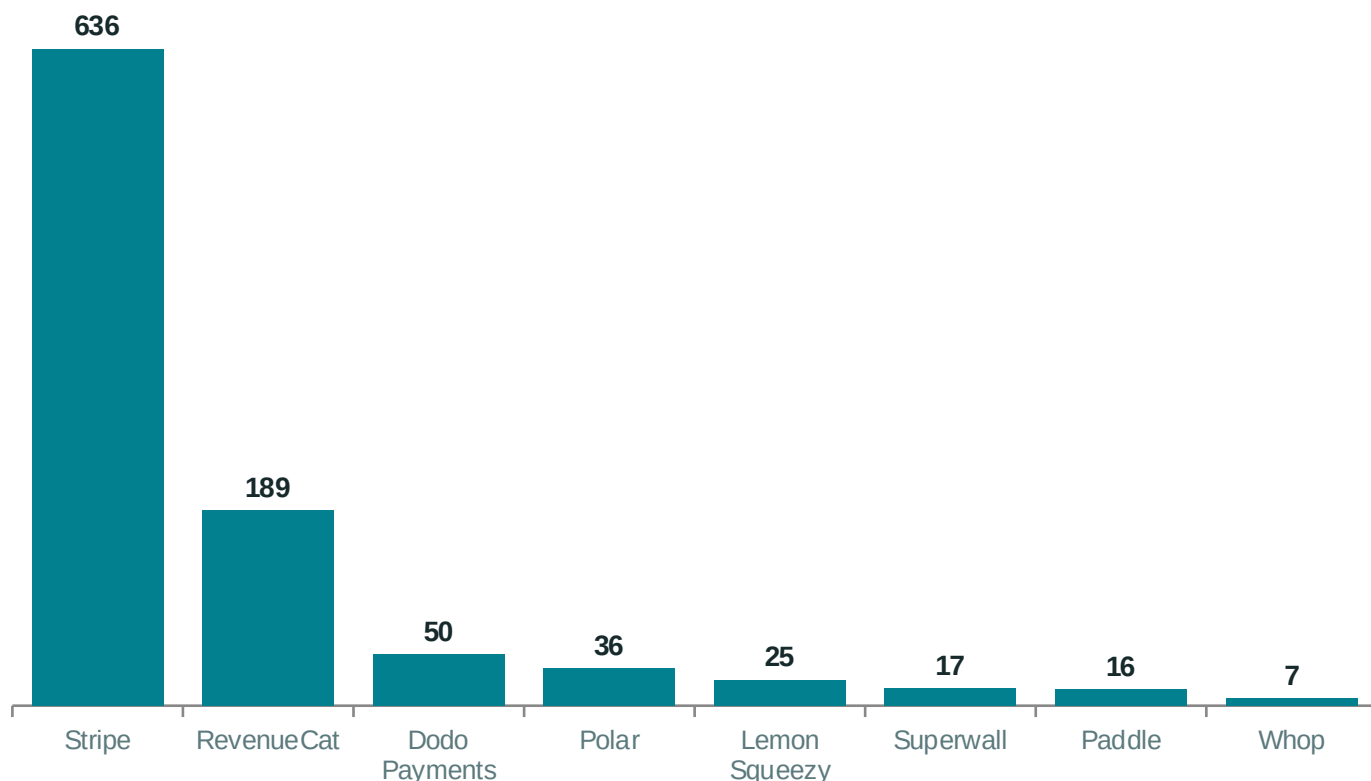
of startups don't disclose any country at all

THE ANSWER Everywhere — but the US leads by far, followed by France and India. This is a genuinely global movement.

QUESTION 6

How Do They Actually Collect the Money?

Payment gateway used, by number of startups



63.6%

of all startups run on Stripe — the default choice for indie founders

But bigger isn't better:

Superwall (mobile paywalls) startups earn a median \$2,999/mo — 4x Stripe's typical \$735/mo.

Polar and Creem users show a \$0 median — newer gateways favored by very early-stage apps.

THE ANSWER Almost everyone defaults to Stripe — but the gateway a founder picks often hints at how mature (or early) their business really is.

QUESTION 7

How Long Before They Start Charging You?

Free-trial length, mined from the pricing text of 657 startups that disclose one

7 days

Median trial length

Half of disclosed trials convert users to paying customers within a week.

3 or 7

Most common trial lengths

3-day and 7-day trials together make up 88% of all disclosed trials.

6.5%

of pricing plans even mention a trial

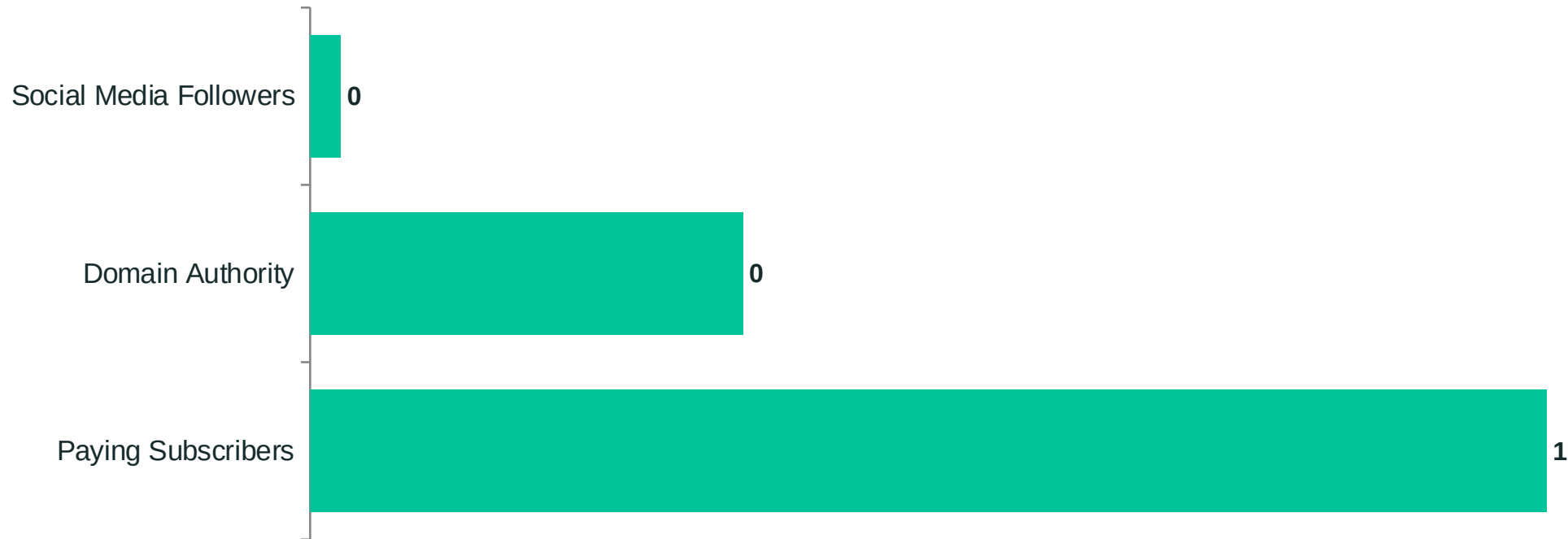
Only 43 of 657 startups with pricing details specify a trial — most charge instantly or don't say.

THE ANSWER Fast. Among founders who reveal it, a single week is the standard window to turn a free user into a paying one.

QUESTION 8

Does a Big Social Media Following Help?

How strongly each metric moves together with revenue (0 = no link, 1 = perfect link)



THE ANSWER Barely. Followers have almost zero link to revenue (0.02) — real paying subscribers are what actually predicts income (0.80).

QUESTION 9

Who Actually Pays More — Businesses or Consumers?

SELLING TO BUSINESSES WINS

\$1,240

median monthly revenue for B2B startups

\$304

median monthly revenue for B2C startups

Even though there are fewer B2B startups (255) than B2C (401), the typical B2B founder earns over 4x more per month than the typical B2C founder.

GROWTH IS A COIN FLIP

35%

Growing

31%

Flat

34%

Declining

Nearly as many startups shrank last month (34%) as grew (35%).
Launching isn't the hard part — staying on an upward trend is.

Also wild: one startup logged a 7,900% month-over-month revenue spike — while several others fell -100% (from something to zero) in the same month.

THE ANSWER Businesses pay businesses more — and growth is fragile: roughly a third of startups are shrinking at any given time.

QUESTION 10

Is Everyone Honest About Who They Are?

Two honesty checks hidden inside the dataset

129

“Stealth Companies”

13% of startups hide their name, website and category entirely — listed, but anonymous.

216

Zero-Revenue Startups

21.6% show \$0 earned last month — likely pre-launch, paused, or abandoned.

THE ANSWER Not entirely — 1 in 8 stays anonymous, and 1 in 5 has effectively no business yet. Treat every listing with a little skepticism.

QUESTION 11

Can You Actually Buy One of These?

TrustMRR doubles as a marketplace — anyone can list their startup to be acquired

262

startups on sale

26% of the dataset — more than 1 in 4

\$35K

median asking price

half ask for more, half for less

2.3x

median revenue multiple

typical price $\approx 2.3 \times$ recent revenue

The surprising twist

Startups listed “for sale” have a HIGHER typical (median) revenue of \$879/month vs. just \$278/month for those not listed. The average looks reversed only because a few giant non-listed startups (like Stan) pull that number up — a reminder that averages can mislead when data is skewed.

THE ANSWER Yes — a quarter of them, typically priced around 2-3x their yearly-ish revenue.

13 Questions, 13 Answers

- 1 Most startups earn very little — median under \$400/month — while a handful earn millions.
- 2 AI is the most-attempted category (1 in 5 startups), but building in it doesn't guarantee revenue.
- 3 Stripe powers 64% of startups, but higher-median-revenue founders often use niche gateways like Superwall.
- 4 Among founders who disclose it, 7 days is the standard trial before charging customers.
- 5 Real paying customers predict revenue — social media followers barely do (0.02 vs 0.80 correlation).
- 6 B2B founders earn 4x more than B2C founders — and growth is a coin flip (34% shrinking vs 35% growing).
- 7 The data itself is imperfect: 13% of founders stay anonymous, and averages can mislead — always check the median.